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Charting a Course Between Methodological Formalism and Eclecticism: Pedagogical Tensions in Three Rhetorical Analysis Textbooks

Sean Zdenek

This review explores how method-oriented approaches to rhetorical criticism are articulated in three textbooks. In method-oriented criticism, methods are abstracted, foregrounded, and separated from each other and from their original contexts. As a number of rhetorical scholars have argued since at least the 1950s, when methods are detached from objects of analysis and when the problem is reduced to one of choosing the best method, the resulting criticism can be mechanical and unimaginative. At issue is how well such an approach serves critical practice and our students in the long run. Critical pluralism in rhetorical studies raises important questions—questions that have no easy, textbook-style answers—about the relationship between theory and practice, method and object, and method and critic. These questions cut to the heart of what it is to be a rhetorical critic. This review is organized around six tensions that both express some of the problems with method-based criticism and point the way to an alternative pedagogy for rhetorical analysis.

Keywords: Rhetorical Criticism; Textual Analysis; Methods; Pedagogy; Textbooks

I should declare at once that I have certain reservations about the concept of “method.” It can too easily be taken as a sort of “transferable skill” if one understands a “method” to be a technique, a tool in a box of tools, which can be resorted to when needed and then returned to the box. (Fairclough, 2001, p. 121)

Methods, then, admit of varying degrees of personality. And criticism, on the whole, is near the indeterminate, contingent, personal end of the methodological scale. In consequence of this placement, it is neither possible nor desirable for

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criticism to be fixed into a system, for critical techniques to be objectified, for critics to be interchangeable for purposes of replication, or for rhetorical criticism to serve as the handmaiden of quasi-scientific theory. (Black, 1965/1978, p. xi)

This review grew out of a disquieting feeling that a pluralist approach to teaching rhetorical analysis¹ was not working—and yet seemed inevitable. Since the publication in 1965 of Edwin Black's *Rhetorical Criticism: A Study in Method*, methods of rhetorical analysis have proliferated (Black, 1965/1978, 1980; Gaonkar, 1990; Jasinski, 2001). According to James Jasinski (2001, p. 253), the 1995 edition of *Index to Journals in Communication Studies* (Matlon & Ortiz, 1997) lists “over sixty critical methods under the heading for methodology in rhetorical criticism,” including:

archetype, axiological, Burkeian, dialectical, dramatic, ethical, existential, factor analysis, fantasy theme, genre studies, historical, inferential, intersubjective, language-action, Marxist, myth or mythological, organismic, phenomenological, philosophical, sociolinguistic, structuralist, and symbolic analysis as well as such idiosyncratic approaches as potlatch, fugue analogy, game theory, and the panel technique.

Many current rhetoric textbooks for both undergraduate and graduate students reflect the triumph of critical pluralism in rhetorical studies. The most popular of these, Sonja Foss' *Rhetorical Criticism: Exploration and Practice* (2004), now in its third edition, provides undergraduate readers with chapters on using the most popular methods of rhetorical analysis. The description of each method in Foss' book follows a standardized meta-procedure—select an artifact, analyze the artifact, formulate a research question, and write the essay (p. 12), and the process of writing the essay is likewise standardized. The critic begins with a discussion of the research question and a description of the artifact, describes the method of analysis, analyzes the artifact, and concludes with a “discussion of the contribution [the critic's] analysis makes to rhetorical theory” (p. 16). As a result, Foss' book streamlines and simplifies what Martin Medhurst (1989, p. 205) calls the “taxing experience” of teaching rhetorical criticism.² For this reason, among others, Foss' book is immensely popular among college-level instructors (the back cover states that the second edition was used at “over 300 schools”).

At issue is how well such an approach serves critical practice (and our students) in the long run. The rise of critical pluralism in rhetorical studies raises important questions—questions that have no easy, textbook-style answers—about the relationship between theory and practice, method and object, and method and critic:

- Quality: Do formal methods have inherent, objective value? Are methods equally valuable? Are some methods more rigorous than others? Since perceptions of quality are often (and sometimes unfairly) tied to larger discussions about the value of quantitative vs. qualitative methods, especially in the humanities and social sciences, how does the textbook-oriented novice critic make distinctions among methods on the basis of quality if all methods look alike, nestled neatly in

their individual compartments/chapters? Can the problem of quality be neatly resolved outside larger, disciplinary-specific discussions about (the politics of) knowledge-making?

- Choice: Do critical methods exist “out there,” waiting to be imported by the critic, as the textbooks imply? Or does choice itself encourage mindless, mechanical criticism—critics merely “possessing a method but not being possessed by it” (Black, 1980, pp. 335–336)? If “relegating method to choice fails to recognize that methodological rules are socially constructed as well as situationally adjusted as they are invoked” (Sullivan & Porter, 2004, p. 308), then how do we teach our students to adapt and design methods rhetorically, according to each situation, rather than import them mechanically by brute force? And finally, how do we teach students to be more skeptical of imported methods and theories as “the distance between the origins of the [interpretive] construct and the particular object of study” increases (Leff, 1980, p. 346)?
- Subjectivism: What role does the critic’s personality play in rhetorical practice? Is critical method “too personally expressive to be systemized” (Black, 1965/1978, p. x)? Or can methods developed in other contexts be successfully mapped onto new objects of analysis whose features are unique and would seem to demand a personalized, contextualized approach? How do we customize and re-contextualize methods? If personality plays a big role in the critical process, then how do we as instructors foster the novice critic’s personality?
- Theory/practice: What does critical practice have to do with theory-building? In other words, how do “abstract constructs relate to concrete particulars” (Leff, 1980, p. 341)? Because the specific relationship between theory (as method) and object is by definition underspecified in formal criticism—that is, formal descriptions of methods cannot fully account for the particular features of the critic’s object of analysis—how does the critic map theory onto practice (so that theory can inform practice without reducing practice to the mechanical imposition of categories) and map practice onto theory (in order to make a contribution to theory through practice)?

These questions cut to the heart of criticism; they are, of course, neither specific to the textbooks nor new to the field of rhetorical studies (e.g., Jasinski, 2001; Leff, 1980). Yet while the field has grappled with these questions for at least 50 years—and in some cases flirted seriously with the idea of renouncing formal methods altogether (e.g., Black, 1980; Bryant, 1957)—they and others are rarely considered in the textbooks in any sustained way. To do so would call into question the pluralist approach itself (and thus also the textbooks), which depends on the assumption that object and method can “drift away” from each other and yet still produce a formula for effective criticism (see Leff, 1980, p. 340). The textbooks operate from the assumption that methods can be detached from objects of criticism, that critics can be detached from methods, and that theoretical frameworks objectively imposed on objects will somehow produce a fresh set of generalizations. The larger question is whether criticism can be systematized, transformed into a science with a formalized

and abstract set of procedures (as the textbooks often imply). If criticism is more art than science, as rhetorical scholars suggest, then how do we help our students develop and apply their critical faculties without reducing the teaching of rhetorical criticism to a set of abstract methods?

When textbooks do broach the questions at the heart of criticism, they often present readers with mixed messages. In introductory chapters authors may espouse “the personality of the researcher” and the extent to which “insight and imagination top statistical applications when studying human action” (Kuypers, 2005, p. 15), but then resort in the remainder of the textbook to formal, objective descriptions of popular methods of criticism. Or they may advocate an “eclectic” approach in which methods are combined creatively in response to specific situations (p. 22), but then isolate methods by placing them neatly into separate chapters. In my experience, these mixed messages or tensions tend to rise to the surface in a method-driven rhetorical analysis course, especially at the graduate level (see Note 5). As they threaten to disrupt the method-driven curriculum, they comprise the basis of an alternative pedagogy.

Method-oriented approaches to criticism are hegemonic, or, as Jasinski (2001, p. 254) put it a few years ago, “method rules.” In method-based textbooks, critical pluralism may be explicitly or implicitly offered as a seemingly uncontested solution to the problems of neo-Aristotelian monism. For example, Foss’ (2004, p. 28) textbook implies that critical pluralism addresses the limitations of neo-Aristotelianism: “Criticisms of how the neo-Aristotelian framework limited the potential of criticism led, in the 1960s, to pluralism in critical approaches. As evident in the remaining chapters of this book, a wide variety of approaches now characterize rhetorical criticism.” While Foss rightly points out that today “critics who use the neo-Aristotelian approach to analyze rhetoric are few,” (p. 28) she does not acknowledge that the solution itself—methodological pluralism—remains contested territory in rhetorical studies, or that neo-Aristotelianism has been adapted in an effort to overcome some of its perceived limitations (e.g., see Mohrmann & Leff, 1974). The debate over method-based criticism and critical pluralism has been playing out in the rhetorical studies literature for a long time, since well before the ashes of neo-Aristotelianism began to cool. The debate hinges on a number of questions: the degree to which methods can be objectified (detached from the critic); the role of the critic’s subjectivity in the critical act; the relationship between theory and practice; the relationship between theory and method; and the function of criticism. These questions are grounded in skepticism regarding the ability of methodological pluralism to solve the main problem with neo-Aristotelianism: “The greatest fault of neo-Aristotelianism is its failure to encourage intensive analysis of texts. But new approaches sometimes embody this fault even as they reject the apparatus of the old criticism” (Leff, 1980, p. 341). In other words, critical pluralism can encourage what Farrell (1980, p. 313) calls “critical disengagement, a failure to take life seriously.” In the worst case, the method-oriented novice critic simply chooses the seemingly best method and imposes its values and categories on an object, rather than “remain[ing] subservient to the meaning of the artifact.”

An alternative approach is to attempt to disavow formal methods altogether, “to coax from the critical object its own essential form of disclosure” (Black, 1980, p. 332). When Black (1980) “eventually came to have second thoughts about methodologically-driven perception” (Jasinski, 2001, p. 251), he offered a thoroughly subjective approach to criticism that “excludes all expectations” (Leff, 1980, p. 344). However, for critics to disavow their expectations (prior theories, methods, and assumptions) in order to disclose fully the object of analysis is not only unrealistic but an extremely hard skill to teach our students, especially undergraduates. What is needed is a method for charting a course between objective criticism (formal methods and assumptions) and subjective criticism (“criticism that interprets its object on the object’s own terms”; Black, 1980, p. 334). To provide such a method, however, is simply not possible from outside the critic’s specific encounter with a rhetorical object, discourse, or transaction—hence the predicament for textbook authors who must chart a general, objective, and not very detailed course when what is needed is a fully contextualized course (i.e., a course for each critic).

In what follows, I explore how these larger questions about method play out in three textbooks: *What Writing Does and How It Does It* (2004) edited by Charles Bazerman and Paul Prior, *Rhetorical Criticism: Exploration and Practice* (2004, 3rd ed.) by Sonja Foss, and *The Art of Rhetorical Criticism* (2005) edited by Jim Kuypers.³ I explore six key tensions that, when made the focus of class discussion, can challenge the perceived dominance of method-oriented criticism. I read the textbooks as pedagogical artifacts that must, by virtue of being storehouses for standardized knowledge, negotiate the tension between rhetorical criticism as a collection of formalized, uncontested procedures and rhetorical criticism as a subjective, creative encounter with a curious artifact.

Pedagogical tensions

Not all rhetorical criticism courses are organized by method, but the method-based approach is certainly the most popular. This approach is a popular option at the undergraduate level and a viable option for more advanced courses. However, despite its popularity, pedagogical questions threaten the integrity of the method-based course and the quality of student criticism. Moreover, it has been the subject of much debate and criticism in the field of communication studies (e.g., see Gaonkar, 1990, p. 297; Nothstine & Copeland, 1987), although to my knowledge no studies have addressed how the debate applies specifically to rhetoric textbooks.

Three method-oriented textbooks are the subject of this review. These textbooks reflect the diversity of the method-based approach. In terms of difficulty level, Foss’ book is intended for beginners, Bazerman and Prior’s book is intended for “advanced undergraduate and graduate students” (back cover), and Kuypers’ book falls somewhere in between, notwithstanding the author’s claim in the Preface that “student accessibility” was a primary concern in the design of the book (p. vii). In terms of disciplinary affiliation, both Foss and Kuypers are affiliated with communication studies, while Bazerman, currently in education, has roots in English

and the study of writing. Prior does writing research in a department of English. Finally, in terms of focus/object, Bazerman and Prior are explicitly interested in “extending the reach of discourse analysis to engage with written text” (p. 1), whereas oratory is the primary object of analysis in Kuypers’ book. While Foss and Kuypers share disciplinary affiliation, their books reflect different emphases, with political discourse (especially speeches) playing a prominent role in Kuypers’ sample essays. The artifacts in Foss’ book are more diverse (speeches, websites, magazine articles, and TV shows, but also non-discursive artifacts such as photographs and works of art and architecture). Taken together, the three texts offer a diverse picture of method-oriented textbooks.

These three books implicitly raise but do not adequately address a number of important questions about how to design and deploy methodologies for analyzing texts. These questions cannot simply be traced to any particular chapter. Instead, they occupy the spaces between chapters—the invisible intertextual connections that student readers, especially graduate students, should be encouraged to draw as they account for similarities and differences among the various methods. When made explicit and nurtured in class, these questions can form the basis of a classroom dialogue that points the way to an alternative pedagogy. Framed as tensions or dialectics, the six interrelated foci discussed in this review are:

- Dependent/independent: Do some methods stand alone? Do other methods depend on more generic or basic methods? Which ones and why? Can every formal method be combined with one or more other methods? If every chapter covers a different method, how do we know when methods need to be combined with other methods?
- One/many: Is one method sufficient? Or should the critic aim to use multiple methods? How many methods are needed? How and when should they be combined? How can a critic who is familiar with the most common formal methods make the transition to informal criticism—the kind used by expert critics—in which methods are “generated” out of the situation?
- Global/local: Under what conditions can methods be treated as generic meta-methods for analyzing texts? Can every method be re-described along a continuum from global and generic to local and specific? How does the critic choose among methods that present their subjects (e.g., narrative, intertextuality, ideology) as all-encompassing?
- Inside/outside rhetoric: Which methods are specific to the field of rhetorical studies? Which have been imported from other disciplines (e.g., sociolinguistics and discourse analysis)? What are the differences between communication studies and English studies in approaches to rhetorical analysis? What are the political implications of adopting one method rather than another?
- Self/other: What is the function of criticism for the critic? Do critics choose curious artifacts in order to generate insight for themselves only? Or is criticism tied to larger disciplinary interests—the questions, conversations, and disagreements that motivate a field?

- Subjective/objective: Do some methods lead to criticism that is inherently more subjective and biased? Is it possible for the critic to remain more detached and objective by choosing methods that are less overtly politicized? What role does the personality of the researcher play in the act of criticism?

As these interconnected questions concern the purpose, politics, scope, and process of doing criticism, they cut to the heart of what it means to be a rhetorical critic. Each dialectic is not a problem to be solved by simply embracing one side over the other. Rather, every dialectic is an opportunity for students to confront a series of tensions that constitute the very act of rhetorical criticism. While the textbooks may acknowledge these tensions, they do an inadequate job of helping students traverse them.

Dependent/Independent

Methods textbooks tend to arrange methods into discrete units, with each unit occupying a single chapter. Each chapter spatially contains a method and thus serves to enforce the idea that methods are independent and mutually exclusive. The most extreme (and most problematic) expression of this tendency is found in Foss' textbook. By alphabetizing the eight chapters/methods that follow the chapter on neo-Aristotelian criticism, Foss' book problematically separates methods that are epistemologically related (and therefore might be more effectively discussed together). Foss appeals to consistency and standardization to explain why the methods/chapters have been alphabetized:

The chapters are organized alphabetically: cluster, fantasy-theme, feminist, generic, ideological, metaphor, narrative, and pentadic criticism. The steps in the process of rhetorical criticism discussed in the chapter are repeated in each of the following chapters to provide a basic framework for criticism that remains constant regardless of your method, artifact, or research question. (p. 23)

What Foss' textbook sacrifices in the interest of consistency and standardization is any real sense of how, if at all, the methods and the theorists associated with each method speak to each other. For example, by putting more than 300 pages between cluster criticism and pentadic criticism—two methods attributed to Kenneth Burke—Foss' textbook detaches methods from the Burkean system out of which they developed.⁴ The result is an incomplete and fragmented attempt to isolate aspects of Burke's system. Foss' textbook also separates feminist criticism from ideological criticism (the chapter on generic criticism comes between them), even though feminist criticism could be treated as a sub-set of ideological criticism, or at least linked to it. Also, fantasy-theme criticism and narrative criticism are separated by 200 pages, even though each method is concerned, albeit in different ways, with stories. A fragmented approach may leave students wondering: if some methods are so obviously interrelated, why are they so severely separated?

Foss' textbook aims, like rhetorical criticism textbooks in general, to introduce students to a range of methods in what might very well be their first introduction to rhetoric, let alone to methods of rhetorical analysis. The easiest way to make an introduction, presumably, is through a process of demarcating, isolating, and standardizing methods. However, the container approach to teaching methods of rhetorical criticism may instill in students the belief that rhetorical methods are not heuristics (see Palczewski, 2003, p. 388; Sullivan & Porter, 2004, p. 301) to be combined, critiqued, and adapted to the critic's specific situation, but inviolable, foundational rules to be followed. Insofar as the sample essays in the textbooks (Foss, Kuypers) are single-method examples (e.g., David Ling's popular pentadic analysis of Kennedy's Chappaquiddick speech), students are encouraged to think of their own papers as applications of single methods (e.g., pentadic analyses). Moreover, when a different expert is solicited to write each chapter (in Bazerman & Prior and in Kuypers, but not in Foss), the impression is not only that methods are distinct but that methods are somehow developed in intellectual vacuums. For example, despite the obvious connections among dramatism, fantasy-theme criticism, and narrative criticism, a student-critic may infer that Burke, Bormann, and Fisher worked in isolation and developed *de novo* unique ways of interpreting texts and situations. Absent from the textbooks is the sense of a multi-disciplinary conversation linking theories and rhetorical exigencies to the development of methodologies to serve specific needs.

The problem, then, is that the textbooks create spatial containers for methods (e.g., by dividing chapters according to method) as well as semantic containers for methods (e.g., by soliciting a different expert to write a single chapter on an assigned method). Explicit cross-fertilization among chapter-methods, not surprisingly, happens rarely and unevenly. When it does happen, it raises questions that threaten the container approach itself. For example, content analysis is described by Thomas Huckin in the first chapter of Bazerman and Prior (p. 14) as a dependent method:

Content analysis makes no claim to being a rich, definitive, or comprehensive method of analysis, as some critics have alleged. Given its limited scope, it cannot be so. Rather, content analysis typically serves only to provide empirical grounding for other more sophisticated methods, such as those detailed in other chapters of this book.

The chapter on the situational perspective is similarly described by Kathleen Farrell and Marilyn Young in Kuypers' textbook (p. 33):

Situational analysis is seldom used as a stand alone tool to evaluate a rhetorical artifact; more typically, it enriches other analytical methods by providing a deeper understanding of context in all its dimensions. Only by understanding the full context of a rhetorical event can the critic comprehend and evaluate the artifact itself.

A key challenge for readers, as a result, is to separate the dependent methods from those that presumably stand alone. This is not an easy task, because the textbooks are

spatially and semantically designed to discourage it and because the implicit assumption in the textbooks, for the most part, is that each method is an island to be mastered. Authors of chapters are not charged with exploring how their assigned method is related to the other methods in the book. The process of combining methods—how does one combine content analysis with another method anyway?—is thus not explained. In the case of the situational perspective, what is dimly apparent in this chapter is that while the situational perspective occupies a space on a par with the other methods in Kuypers' book, it is in fact always used, to some degree, by the rhetorical critic, just typically not to the full extent that Farrell and Young use it in their sample essay. While it is not possible, outside the critic's specific situation, to specify how much contextual or situational analysis should be included in the critic's essay, the question itself (and thus the larger question of dependency) is not addressed in the chapter by Farrell and Young.

One/Many

Questions related to the number of methods a critic might employ arise inevitably in the rhetorical criticism classroom. The tension between dependent and independent methods, for example, gives rise to concerns about which methods to use and how many methods comprise an appropriate methodology. Given the decidedly qualitative and uncertain nature of rhetorical analysis, it is not possible, obviously, to quantify methods formally. Still, textbooks often send students mixed messages about questions of quality and quantity. Textbook writers appear to recognize the problem at the heart of textbooks organized by method—namely that textbooks quantify and fragment a process that is inherently qualitative, contextual, and holistic. Both Kuypers and Foss gesture in the direction of a different kind of criticism—one not based on formal, rigid methods—even as they devote their textbooks, ironically, to descriptions of formal methods. In one of his introductory chapters, Kuypers (p. 22) promotes what he calls “eclectic criticism,” that is, criticism not bound by the rigidity and detachment of a formal method. This method is based on Black's notion of “assimilation,” in which the instrument or method has “become an integral part of the critic's mode of perception,” as opposed to a tool to be used in a detached, mechanical way (Black, cited in Kuypers, p. 22). Kuypers writes: “A minority of critics, myself included, take the process of assimilation one step further by blending and developing their own framework from which to proceed with criticism. This type of criticism is often called *eclectic* criticism.” (p. 22) Kuypers gives an example from his own work in which he “discovered that no single perspective would do justice to the rich intellectual and moral cultures embedded within [the artifact]” (p. 22). Kuypers' solution was to develop “a *method* of analysis (criticism) that blended *perspectives* (judgmental analysis [sic] and Burkean dramatism).” (p. 22) Eclecticism is a promising alternative to strict formalism. However, because Kuypers' book is devoted to a description of formal, isolated methods, there is little room (beyond a few references to co-dependency) for a discussion of how or whether to blend. The tension between formalism and eclecticism raises important questions, but because

Kuypers' book is arranged by method, the tension tends, unfortunately, to be resolved in favor of strict formalism. In the textbooks, the one trumps the many: single methods are preferred to the design of methodologies that draw eclectically on many methods.

Whereas Kuypers (p. 22) attributes the eclectic approach to a "minority of critics," Foss (p. 411) attributes "generative criticism" to the field itself. Foss opens the chapter on generative criticism—the last chapter in her book—with a distinction between the formal methods that make up everything that precedes this final chapter and an informal, generative approach:

The previous chapters in this book have provided you with an approach to doing criticism when your starting point is a particular method of criticism. Starting with a method produces some good insights and is a comfortable way to begin doing criticism if you are an inexperienced critic. Most seasoned rhetorical critics, however, engage in rhetorical criticism using a different process, and that process is the subject of this chapter. As useful as the formal methods of criticism are for discovering insights into rhetoric, they do not always allow what is most interesting and significant in an artifact to be captured and explained. In most cases, then, you will want to analyze artifacts without following any formal method of criticism. (p. 411)

Generative criticism is similar to eclectic criticism in that the critic does not start with a formal method but with a "curious artifact" and the critic's (evolving) research question. In short, method follows, or is developed in dialectical conversation with, artifact and research question. A method is not imposed on the artifact from outside but develops or is "generated" out of a careful consideration of the rhetorical discourse from the perspective of the critic's own research question(s). The generative approach thus appears to be more in keeping with what Black (1980, p. 336) calls a "total commitment" to the rhetorical transaction, a commitment in which the critic herself is the method and as a result her engagement with the subject is direct and unmediated by external methods (Black, 1965/1978, p. xi). Regardless, Foss' final chapter problematically calls into question the rationale for everything that precedes it (i.e., more than 400 pages). While Foss' rationale addresses the need for "comfortable" method-first criticism tailored to the needs of the "inexperienced critic," it is based on the implicit assumption that the critic who has mastered the formal methods will be able to move effortlessly into grown-up criticism. This assumption is problematic. It raises questions about the (possibly poor) quality of criticism that may result from a method-first, foundational approach that professional critics no longer find very useful. According to James Jasinski (2001, p. 254), there is "growing evidence that the hegemony of method-based criticism is coming to an end." Regardless of the status of method today, the tension in Foss' textbook between formal and generative criticism (the one and the none) raises questions that threaten the rationale for the book itself. If formal methods "do not always allow what is most interesting and significant in an artifact to be captured and explained," then why should we impose on our students an overly simplified, hopelessly impaired understanding of rhetorical criticism? If we agree that a pedagogy of formal methods

is a good “starting point” for our students, then do we also agree that our students will be able to jump ship at the end of the semester in favor of generative-based anti-methods that require them to do what they did not learn to do in the course—namely, search the literature for theoretical explanations and resist “cookie cutter criticism” (Foss, p. 417)?

The argument in favor of textbook-style formalism, particularly at the undergraduate level, rests on the notion that students need to take baby steps before they can grow into mature, adult-critics. My experience in the classroom tells me that such a view indeed has merit. Where better to start than with a textbook that neatly and clearly demarcates the terrain into individual methods and procedures? Still, the human development metaphor of rhetorical criticism pedagogy (“You must learn to walk first”) remains problematic for a number of reasons:

- After we show students how to walk, will they be able to learn how to run on their own? They might. Of course, we could always show them how to run, or give them the tools needed to remove the training wheels—but will we have the time to do so, especially after we have spent the entire semester giving them the baby’s tools? More important is the question of whether the baby’s tools provide the necessary training in the first place. Foss does not think so (see the quote above). The brightest and most motivated of our students may not need us to show them how to be grown-up critics, but I worry about the majority of our students who, after they have taken our department’s only course in rhetorical criticism, will have no reason to question the formalist, narrow mindset at the heart of textbook criticism.
- How compatible are formalism and generative criticism, anyway? The human development metaphor assumes that strict formalism and cookie-cutter criticism are important precursors to doing adult criticism: searching the literature for theoretical problems, adapting methods to artifacts and situations, reading artifacts emically, developing customized or eclectic methodologies, and joining a community. However, grown-up criticism is, in many ways, located on an entirely different timeline. While grown-up critics are working with some of the same strategies as their presumably former baby selves, they are also engaged in a set of activities that transcend immature criticism.
- How do we address the issue of graduate students who are taking courses in rhetoric for the first time? At my institution, rhetoric courses provide the foundation for our graduate programs in technical communication. A good number of graduate students who have taken my rhetorical analysis course have told me they appreciate the grounding that a textbook provides. However, textbooks do not offer a sufficient introduction to the subject—the grown-up version of the subject—at the graduate level. Scholarly articles provide a needed supplement, especially when they confront some of the tensions I discuss in this review, or when they put the rise of critical pluralism in an historical context going back to Wichelns (1925/2005). It would be a mistake to treat the textbooks as though they simply provided the foundation for advanced study. As Foss implies

in the quote above, the textbooks provide a perspective that does not merely pave the way for professional criticism but, in some ways, conflicts with it. They are different processes, according to Foss, and it is arguable whether one process is simply an introduction to or training for the other process.

When discussing generative criticism and eclecticism, the textbooks seem to be compatible with the professional critic's point of view. However, the textbooks present mixed messages. Both Foss and Kuypers identify with a process (eclecticism/generative criticism) that conflicts with the basic arrangement of their textbooks into formal methods. Conflicts are opportunities, especially at the advanced level, to discuss with students the assumptions about criticism that inform both the formalist and the alternative process.

Global/Local

Methods may depend on other methods, as suggested above, despite the appearance of parity across chapters. Methods may also be described in terms of all-inclusive meta-concepts, although there is no way of predicting in advance which concepts will take on global significance. A concept takes on global significance when it is (re)described as an umbrella term for understanding any text. In a method-based course, students are typically shuttled from one global concept to another: everything is ideology one week, then narrative the next, then metaphor, and so on. For textbook editors who assign each method to a different expert (Bazerman & Prior, Kuypers), it is not unusual to find a number of perspectives described globally, because each expert makes a case for the significance of the perspective with which s/he may be affiliated professionally. When confronted with a number of competing global perspectives, as well as a number of other perspectives that are described as dependent, students inevitably begin to wonder how to negotiate different global systems. While students are often savvy enough to let their own research interests and artifacts guide them, the method-based textbooks are not designed to provide a meta-discussion of the differences between two or more systems with global aspirations.

Two examples from Bazerman and Prior's textbook may suffice to suggest how the drive to globalize can create pedagogical tensions in the classroom. In the chapter on "Poetics and Narrativity," Philip Eubanks opens with a discussion of "basic concepts" in narrative theory—for example, "two or more" events, "a complication" in the story (p. 34)—before breaking down the distinction between "narrative and non-narrative texts" (p. 35). By conflating narrative and non-narrative texts, Eubanks globalizes narrative. The study of narrative is equated with "the study of culture" itself (p. 36). Eubanks offers two reasons why the study of narrative has become so important:

The first answer is provided by postmodernism. Postmodernism is attuned to **grand narratives** or **metanarratives**—stories that pervade, shape, and, it is often asserted, delude cultures. Postmodernists argue that the very prevalence of some

narratives makes them largely invisible and, at the same time, inescapably intermingled with institutions, practices, and texts. Even so-called non-narrative scientific texts—and thus science itself—cannot escape the molding power of grand narratives. . . . Narrative is also important in a second and complementary way. Cognitive scientists are interested in the structure and function of language as an indicator of the workings of the mind—or, some would prefer to say, the brain. Along with metaphor, narrative is one of the most observable ways we conceptualize experience and organize memory. (pp. 35–36, emphasis in original)

Both reasons globalize narrative. Narrative is pervasive, invisible. It is inside our heads. We live by it in the same way we are said to live by metaphor (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980/2003). When narrative becomes invisible, it goes global. For the classroom instructor, then, the pedagogical challenge is to help students understand that a global concept need not be globally, mechanically applied to every artifact. Despite the pervasiveness of narrative (in our texts and in our heads), a narrative perspective, ironically, may not produce the greatest insight into a rhetorical artifact. This important distinction is left unstated in Eubank's chapter on narrative.

This pedagogical challenge is made difficult by the ubiquity of pervasive concepts in Bazerman and Prior's text. Intertextuality is another globalized (invisible) concept. The chapter "Intertextuality: How Texts Rely on Other Texts," written by Bazerman, offers levels of intertextuality that range from the visible and quantifiable (such as source texts) to the amorphous and omnipresent (such as idioms and other "resources of language"; p. 88). The six levels move from the more explicit to the less explicit, with the less explicit levels (four through six) subsuming and encompassing language itself and thus the critic's artifact:

4. Less explicitly the text may rely on **beliefs, issues, ideas, statements generally circulated** and likely familiar to the readers . . .
5. By using certain implicitly **recognizable kinds of language, phrasing, and genres**, every text evokes particular social worlds where such language and language forms are used . . .
6. Just by using language and language forms, a text relies on the available **resources of language** without calling particular attention to the intertext. Every text, all the time, relies on the available language of the period and is part of the cultural world of the times. (pp. 87–88, emphasis in original)

As the concept of intertextuality merges with the concept of language, it loses its value as a critical tool. If everything—"every text, all the time"—is intertextual, then how useful is it to say that a text is intertextual? The same question has been asked about another globalized term: *rhetoric* (Gaonkar, 1997; Schiappa, 2001). If everything is rhetorical, so the critique goes, then nothing is. For novice critics, it can be intimidating to analyze an artifact from an intertextual perspective if there is, literally, no place to start, or if, alternatively, every place in the text is as good as any other. The overwhelmed critic might start anywhere. Bazerman acknowledges the methodological challenges involved in studying intertextuality. Whereas the easier task for the

critic, he writes, is to study “explicit overt references to other authors” (p. 91), a much more difficult task is to “look at unattributed or background intertextuality” (p. 92).

As intertextuality at its most globalized level is indistinguishable from language itself, there really is no easy way to formalize the study of it, even in a textbook like Bazerman and Prior’s devoted to the formalization of methods of text analysis. This problem is evident when the critic must explain the less explicit forms of intertextuality in an artifact:

[I]f a word or phrase seems out of keeping with the general tone, level, or sets of words [in the critic’s artifact], we might wonder where these words came from, what other kind of document they might reflect, and if there any [sic] other similar borrowings in the text. (p. 92)

While advanced students may be able to identify those elements in the text that seem “out of keeping,” they will probably have a much harder time explaining why and where those elements came from without embarking on a comprehensive and life-long study of language, culture, and history. The challenge for the instructor, then, is to localize terms such as “intertextuality.” One way to do this is to reverse the relationship between method and object. Rather than starting from a globalized meaning of intertextuality, instructors must challenge students to start with a curious artifact or an assigned theme (Henry & Sharp, 1989). For example, a series of news articles on a current, provocative topic will allow students to explore the various ways in which a news story is reported and framed across multiple, similar (inter)texts. Instructors should not reject the world of possibilities inherent in a globalized concept, but they should offer students local boundaries that will ultimately provide scaffolding for the study of less explicit levels of intertextuality.

Another way of thinking about the global/local tension is in terms of methods that lose their specificity and take on the status of meta-methods—that is, generic or global methods for doing any kind of text analysis. For example, the method for content analysis, according to Huckin’s description (Bazerman & Prior, pp. 16–19), seems generic enough to transcend the specific method in question: pose a research question; define the appropriate construct(s); select an appropriate text or body of texts as the study corpus; determine appropriate units of analysis (text features), using multiple raters if possible; gather data; and interpret the findings. Granted, these instructions reflect the emphasis in content analysis on quantitatively-oriented procedures such as the use of a corpus and multiple raters. Moreover, Huckin suggests how “a statistical test can be used to determine if the data constitutes a statistically significant pattern” (p. 18). Nevertheless, the process described in Huckin’s chapter is also general enough to serve as a meta-method for doing criticism. That the procedure is more general than specific, however, is neither made explicit in the chapter nor compared to other procedures described in other chapters. Students thus run the risk of equating methods that might be better situated along a global/local continuum.

Another generic meta-method is “linguistic discourse analysis” as described by Ellen Barton in Bazerman and Prior’s textbook. Barton draws on earlier research by Huckin to describe a method for doing discourse analysis called “rich feature analysis” (pp. 65–66): select an initial corpus; identify salient patterns; determine “interestingness”; select a study corpus; verify the pattern; and develop a functional-rhetorical analysis. The method is clearly basic, but students may not be aware that it is generic or that it is the result of Barton’s effort to simplify a very complex, multidisciplinary, and wide-ranging subject such as discourse analysis. The method Barton describes is not inherent to linguistic discourse analysis by any means (despite the title of Barton’s chapter). In fact, Barton might have defined linguistic discourse analysis very differently. (Considering that the editors use “discourse analysis” as the organizing theme for the book [p. 1], Barton might have taken any number of approaches.) Defining a corpus, looking for salient patterns, choosing an interesting pattern to study, and then interpreting it are not specific to the method Barton describes but in fact comprise a meta-method for doing text analysis more generally. Students are not typically aware of a given method’s scope (how general or specific it is), how it compares with other methods in terms of scope, and the context of its development (in this case, the context for Barton is sociolinguistics). As textbooks are not designed to help students address these issues, the instructor needs to help them become sensitive to the implicit hierarchy at work. While the methods in Bazerman and Prior’s text are spatially and semantically presented as/in identical containers, they might be more effectively re-described for students along a continuum from generic to specific (or global to local). In other words, some containers could effectively fit inside other containers, at least for the purpose of the critic’s analysis.

The container metaphor serves an important function in this review, because it suggests how textbooks isolate and fragment methods of criticism. However, re-describing methods as global or local does not mean that some methods are always generic meta-methods, and that others are always intended for specific situations. Rather, it suggests that distinctions between methods on the basis of scope have not been made. The textbooks discussed here are not designed to account for differences between methods/chapters. Making such distinctions, however, might begin to move the textbooks towards a more rhetorical understanding of methods of text analysis, in which techniques for doing research are “adapted to the locally grounded and contingent arguments we make, even as those techniques are presented as stable and unchanging building blocks” (Spinuzzi, 2005, p. 413). In other words, the distinction between global and local, or generic and specific, arises in the context of a particular study; it is not made in advance. Similarly, Kuypers (p. 19) urges critics not to allow a perspective “to *dictate* rather than *guide*” the analysis, because the result may be “stale and lifeless criticism.” However, his warning, like his preference for “eclectic criticism” in the same introductory chapter, does not disrupt his textbook’s main strategy of placing methods into separate containers. Insofar as the textbooks present methods as clear-cut and cut off from each other, they may give students, in spite of claims to the contrary, the false impression that methods are the

same in terms of scope, pre-defined in advance, and not meant to be adapted, combined, or critiqued to suit the critic's purpose.

Inside/Outside Rhetoric

A course in analyzing texts might take a number of approaches and reflect a number of disciplinary orientations. In this review, more than one term describes the subject—rhetorical analysis, rhetorical criticism, text analysis, discourse analysis—because the textbooks in question do not share one disciplinary orientation. Jim Kuypers is affiliated with speech communication: his textbook adopts the term “rhetorical criticism” (the standard term in his field), his book's contributors all hail from communication departments, and the majority of sample essays analyze speeches as artifacts. Bazerman and Prior's collection takes a different approach: the organizing term is “discourse analysis” (p. 1), the contributors are affiliated with many fields (linguistics, communication studies, rhetoric, education, etc.), and “rhetorical analysis” (a term often affiliated with English departments) is treated as one method/chapter (as opposed to an organizing concept for the book itself). Either of these books could be used effectively in either department (communication or English). However, each book's biases must be a topic for discussion in class, especially at the advanced or graduate level. Helping students understand how rhetoric is positioned in the academy, and how it is positioned differently in different departments, will give them a better sense of the big picture and how their critical essays fit into that picture. Rhetorical analysis/criticism is defined in multiple ways; it is affiliated with more than one academic department; its status as a meta-discipline is currently contested (Gaonkar, 1997). For these reasons, students, particularly graduate students, need to understand how disciplinary forces shape the textbooks they read and the discipline(s) of rhetoric to which they are exposed. In short, they need to face multiple ways of understanding and defining rhetorical criticism/analysis. They will be better able, as a result, to situate rhetoric, their course, the artifacts they write about, and their own writing within a field of study—a community of scholars—that transcends the classroom. At the undergraduate level, instructors might replace the need to situate rhetoric as a discipline-specific pursuit with the need to help students understand how their methodological choices and treatment of rhetoric can be responsive to their audience's understanding of criticism and (mere) rhetoric outside the academy.

When adopted in a rhetorical analysis course, the Bazerman and Prior textbook inevitably raises questions of rhetoric's scope. While rhetorical analysis occupies only one chapter, written by Jack Selzer, it resonates in other chapters. For example, Anne Wysocki's chapter on “The Multiple Media of Texts” adopts a “rhetorical approach (using both textual and contextual analysis, as Jack Selzer describes in his chapter on rhetorical analysis) for analyzing texts made up of multiple media” (p. 123). In addition, Eubanks' chapter on narrative and metaphor raises implicit questions about the extent to which figurative language might be included under the lexicon of classical rhetoric (as opposed to “narrative theory and poetics”), particularly the

canon of Style, which Selzer discusses in terms of metaphor and other figures (p. 284). In other words, these traces of rhetoric in other chapters lead to questions in class about where rhetoric begins and ends—the same questions rhetorical studies has been asking for some time (Schiappa, 2001). However, the textbooks do not address these questions.

Despite being relegated to one chapter, the method of rhetorical analysis is described globally in Bazerman and Prior's book: Selzer describes "rhetorical analysis as a kind of critical reading" (p. 281) and suggests that the "classical terminology"—the focus of the chapter—"is not the only rhetorical terminology, by any means" (p. 285). Other terminologies, according to Selzer, include feminism, argumentation theories inspired by Stephen Toulmin, theories inspired by Kenneth Burke, and cultural studies (p. 285). Rhetoric is thus defined as a global meta-discipline that swallows up the processes of interpretation themselves. Rather than question how broadly Selzer defines rhetoric, I call attention to a pedagogical challenge: How do we help our students understand the professional implications, about which this chapter and the textbook are silent, of aligning themselves with one or more of these terminologies? As Selzer does not discuss the disciplinary implications of using the classical terminology (or any terminology for that matter), students limited to Bazerman and Prior's text are unaware of the history of neo-Aristotelianism and the rise of critical pluralism in the wake of critiques of neo-Aristotelianism in the 1960s and later (Black, 1965/1978). Without this context, methods become detached and isolated. The classical approach seems as good as any other. However, when placed in a disciplinary context, the classical approach is more clearly recognized as a problematic one. What is missing from this textbook discussion, and from the textbooks generally, is a framework for situating methods in the context of disciplinary politics and community knowledge-building.

Self/Other

Textbooks are generally designed to help students become excited about being rhetorical critics. This is an understandable and admirable goal, but it runs the risk of ignoring one of the main reasons why professional critics write critical essays: to contribute to the creation and sharing of disciplinary knowledge. By adopting a method-first, me-first approach, textbooks lose sight of the disciplinary picture. For example, Foss' textbook, which is appropriate for undergraduates and novice critics, describes a standardized procedure for doing rhetorical criticism that starts with the selection of an artifact. In the case of ideological criticism (to take just one example), Foss explains the first step:

Virtually any artifact can serve as an artifact for ideological criticism because ideologies exist almost everywhere. Although you may be tempted to select a political text for ideological analysis—and such texts certainly work well as data for this kind of analysis—other kinds of artifacts often can produce less obvious insights. (p. 244)

By starting with the selection of an artifact, Foss' book eases the burden on novice critics to learn how to do (one type of) criticism. In the case of advanced textbooks, however, it is doubtful whether the trade-off (putting self-interests over the interests of the wider community of critics) will serve students in the long run.

Likewise, Selzer's chapter on rhetorical analysis in Bazerman and Prior's textbook suggests that the end of criticism is the critic's own understanding and appreciation of the artifact:

[C]ritical reading—rhetorical analysis, that is—involves studying carefully some kind of symbolic action . . . so that you might understand it better and appreciate its tactics. (p. 281)

But as a rhetorical analyst your job is not so much to react to these rhetorical acts as to understand them better, to appreciate the rhetorical situation . . . (p. 282)

[Rhetorical analysis] involves not simply passively decoding a message but actively understanding the designs the message has for readers who are living and breathing within a given culture. (p. 293)

In these examples, Selzer's rationale for doing criticism is critic-oriented; nowhere do we find in this chapter the argument that criticism might ultimately be anything more than a road to self-awareness and self-understanding. While professional critics are obviously drawn to rhetorical situations and artifacts for the greater understanding and appreciation they can provide to the critic, they are also typically motivated by a desire to contribute to an ongoing disciplinary conversation or to serve as mediators of the public's understanding of texts. Instructors negotiate this tension in the classroom, as they help students, especially advanced students, not only to appreciate curious artifacts for themselves but also to appeal to a disciplinary community that lies beyond the confines of the textbook and thus to negotiate the politics of knowledge-making. In the case of undergraduate students, the community may not be disciplinary so much as public (e.g., other students in the classroom, other students in the university, the local community beyond the borders of the university, etc.).

At the end of the last section, I suggested that advanced students need a clearer understanding of how methods are situated in their field. Sample essays in textbook chapters play a significant role in framing methods within a larger context of artifacts and research questions. However, when the emphasis is on describing a method and not on situating that method within a disciplinary context, the result is artificial criticism. For example, the chapter in Kuypers (p. 36) on the situational perspective, discussed previously, devotes the entire sample essay to "treat[ing] situational analysis as an isolated tool," despite the claim made by the authors just two sentences earlier: "Situational analysis is seldom used as a stand alone tool to evaluate a rhetorical artifact" (p. 35). Why devote an entire essay to the situational perspective if it is seldom used that way?

The artificiality of the sample essay genre is referred to repeatedly in William Benoit's sample essay on "generic rhetorical criticism" (Kuypers, p. 85):

My goal in the essay that follows is not so much to present a standard academic essay, but rather to demonstrate the process of both generic description and generic application. (p. 96)

I was able to locate two studies of inaugural addresses as a genre. Given that my analysis here is designed simply to illustrate the process of generic criticism, I will not review this work. However, in a standard academic essay, this literature should be reviewed and also drawn into the evaluation section, discussing points of similarity and difference between your analysis and previous research on speeches in the genre. (p. 97)

If this were intended as more than an illustration of the process of generic rhetorical criticism, I would at this point return to the literature on inaugurals and discuss points of similarity and difference between my findings and theirs. I would also spend more time teasing out specifics. (p. 101)

Once again, if this were intended as a complete rhetorical criticism, I would discuss the relationship of this analysis to prior research on inaugurals. (p. 102)

If the goal of rhetorical criticism is “simply to illustrate” how a method works, Benoit succeeds. However, if the process of doing rhetorical criticism is always tied to larger disciplinary or public interests—the questions, conversations, and disagreements that motivate a field of scholars or members of the public—then Benoit’s essay is less helpful, not only for graduate students who are in the process of entering that larger conversation but also for undergraduate students who may not see how rhetorical criticism can serve the public’s interests by mediating the public’s understanding of the role and power of language.⁵ With graduate education, the issue is whether the academic pursuit of rhetorical criticism can be taught in the vacuum created by Benoit’s sample essay. While Benoit acknowledges the artificiality of the task and how he would do things differently in a “standard academic essay,” his explanations (i.e., review the literature, connect findings to the literature) are still inadequate. Benoit’s process remains artifact-centered: he selected artifacts that interested him, and then searched the literature for previous research on those artifacts (but then didn’t concern himself with the previous research he found). The interests of the academic community are seemingly little more than an after-thought, as opposed to an integral and recursive part of the thinking and writing process.

An alternative pedagogy is grounded in community, defined broadly. In Kuypers’ textbook, accessibility seems to trump community: since the discipline-oriented sample essays in other textbooks “were often written for the readers of a particular scholarly journal, they are not easily accessible to students. Because of this, they may actually defeat their purpose of providing useful examples of criticism for new critics to emulate” (p. vii). Kuypers’ point is well taken: the journal articles reprinted as sample essays in Foss’ textbook can be difficult for novice critics. Kuypers explains in his Preface that student accessibility “drove the creation” of his book (p. vii). Yet Kuypers at times embraces accessibility at the expense of complexity and community. By implying that rhetorical criticism can effectively be undertaken in a disciplinary vacuum, Kuypers’ textbook divorces criticism from community. Outside of a discourse

community, criticism is reduced to an artificial exercise, in which the critic applies a method to an artifact and generates insight for herself, but does not link the exercise to a larger research question or public debate (one that motivates the community) or otherwise demonstrate why an audience of critics in the field should be interested in such an exercise.

Subjective/Objective

Students need to recognize that the choice of one method over another is a political one. Two methods may or may not be grounded on the same epistemological assumptions. Alphabetizing methods, as Foss does, obscures the epistemological connections between them. So does the process of assigning a different expert to write each chapter/method. When textbooks do not make room for a meta-discussion that crosses chapter boundaries, readers may not be fully aware of the implications of choosing, for example, feminist criticism over framing analysis. Kuypers raises this concern in one of his introductory chapters; I borrow the subjective/objective distinction from him:

It is clear that criticism is not a scientific act; the very best criticism involves the personality, insights, and imagination of a critic. Yet for all that, there are critics—I among them—who maintain that a certain degree of objectivity is necessary for honest, productive criticism. When I use the term “objective,” I do not mean that critics ought to possess or are capable of possessing a scientific detachment from the object of criticism. This would surely produce a sterile criticism devoid of its lifeblood: the critic’s intermingled intuition, insight, and personality. What I am suggesting is that the critic may approach the artifact under consideration with a fair and open mind. In this sense the critic sets aside personal politics or ideological “truths” and approaches the artifact with a sense of curiosity. (p. 25)

This distinction is useful insofar as it encourages students to reflect on the ways in which some methods are explicitly politicized. A politicized methodology is one in which the critic’s personal politics guides her analysis. The subjective critic’s aim, according to Kuypers, is “to produce partisan social change in the direction of that critic’s choosing.” (p. 25) Kuypers’ own position (objectivity over political ideology) is reinforced in the chapter that follows, an essay by Edwin Black. Black argues that politicized criticism is overly mechanical and predictable: the political critic simply interprets an artifact through the lens of her pre-existing ideology. The result is criticism that is “in the service of an ideology” and therefore “impersonal” and “excessively objective” (p. 30).

Kuypers’ distinction between objective and subjective criticism is a useful tool in the classroom, because it helps students see beyond individual methods. Methods that may appear separate and unique can be brought together because they share similar politics. However, Kuypers’ admitted bias prematurely closes off discussion. Gone is the sense of tension between subjective and objective criticism. Both Kuypers and Black dismiss socio-political criticism and thus call into question a set of

methods we might call postmodern—covered by the last three chapters in Kuypers’ book—feminist analysis, ideographic criticism, and critical rhetoric. Moreover, Kuypers implies that some methods are more inherently objective when he contrasts “framing analysis and feminist criticism.” Tellingly, Kuypers has written a book using the framing method (Kuypers, 2002). If we adopt a rhetorical approach to methods (in which methods are constructed and adapted rather than transported; Sullivan & Porter, 2004, p. 311), then it becomes increasingly difficult to maintain the claim that some methods are inherently more objective or subjective than others. Likewise, it is difficult from a rhetorical perspective to maintain the claim that political critics are any more affected by personal feelings than so-called objective critics. In other words, the tension between subjective and objective criticism is threatened when Kuypers decides for students in advance that some methods serve up stronger magic than others. To decide in advance is to embrace a form of foundationalism in which some methods are viewed as inherently better, more objective, or more rigorous. By appealing to “some external sense of rigor” (p. 309) that presumably inheres in certain methods, the researcher may be prevented from fully accounting for the “impact of the situation” (p. 311) on the research design. An alternative pedagogy would encourage students to explore, more freely than Kuypers has allowed, these and other tensions (such as object/method; Gaonkar, 1990) that cut to the heart of what it means to be a rhetorical critic.

Conclusion

This review of three method-oriented textbooks is grounded on the idea that the process of doing rhetorical criticism should itself be *rhetorical*. A rhetorical view promotes a process of research whose elements—theory, method, artifact, question/problem—are equally responsive to the situation and to each other. When methods are viewed as static, external, and detached from the rhetorical situation, the result may be weak, robotic, predictable, and “fateful” criticism (Black, 1980, p. 331). When viewed rhetorically, methods are responsive, flexible, and locally instantiated. They are more akin to social constructs that the committed critic places in dialectical interaction with other elements in the research design. Method shapes and is shaped through such interaction. The end result is more responsible, more invested criticism than the fateful kind based on borrowed theoretical and methodological commitments. Rhetorically-minded criticism “demand[s] total commitments”—it is “not an enterprise for triflers” (p. 336) who import methods and theories uncritically. To accept uncritically a collection of methods developed outside the critic’s specific research nexus, no matter how proven, is to reinforce the foundationalism of a received tradition, what Sullivan and Porter (2004, p. 311) call “the sanctities of method.”

The challenge for rhetorical critics is to balance the need to generalize from specific cases (to build theory) with the recognition that each research opportunity is unique and requires a unique approach. Rhetorical critics must maneuver through a series of tensions: general/specific, formal/informal, and imported/constructed. The goal is

not simply to embrace one side of the tension over the other—for example, to import a formal method this time and construct an informal, ad hoc methodology next time. Rather, doing rhetorical criticism is about negotiating these tensions without presupposing an analytical framework in advance. To maintain a sense of tension in the critical act is to situate the practice of rhetorical criticism *rhetorically*. From this perspective, formal methods clearly have an important role to play as critics negotiate (challenge, adopt, shape, or discard) the received methodological wisdom of the past. However, the sense of play inherent in this view of research—the open-ended negotiations and interactions through which the critic builds a situationally-responsive research framework—is muted in the textbooks. While textbook editors may gesture in the direction of methodological eclecticism (Kuypers, p. 22) and generative, informal criticism (Foss, Ch. 12), their books more often encourage a tool-kit approach (Bazerman, p. 4) in which methods are reduced to a series of inviolable steps, compartmentalized, uncritically globalized, politically and disciplinarily neutralized, and so on. If the ultimate goal is eclectic, responsive, and totally committed criticism, then it is unclear how removing the tension at the heart of the critical act—by making criticism “comfortable” for inexperienced critics (Foss, p. 411)—will provide the scaffolding our students need to become responsible, insightful critics who, in Black’s (2005, p. 31) words, surprise their readers.

Notes

- [1] The course has two primary names: *rhetorical analysis* and *rhetorical criticism*. It may have other names as well: *methods of text analysis*, *discourse analysis*, and *rhetorical theory*, among others. Often, course names betray disciplinary origins: *rhetorical criticism* is typically linked to communication studies, and *rhetorical analysis* is more often used in English departments. In this paper, I tend to use “criticism” and “analysis” interchangeably because the textbooks I analyze operate from different disciplinary bases and because my argument is not specific to one discipline. While I do not have space here to explore the history or nature of the differences between courses in criticism offered in communication studies and English studies, I argue later in this review that students can benefit from a clearer understanding of the disciplinary assumptions about criticism that inform the criticism course they are taking and the textbook (if any) they are using. These assumptions may be hidden in individual textbook chapters.
- [2] Medhurst (1989, p. 205) offers “several and well known” reasons why “the teaching of rhetorical criticism, especially to the undergraduate audience, is a taxing experience”:

the undergraduate’s lack of knowledge about all things rhetorical, especially rhetorical theory; the lack of familiarity with oratory in general and specific speeches in particular; poor preparation in history, politics, and other cognate fields; generally low writing skills that sometimes seem to defy comment, much less correction; and the ever present problems of time and resources. Add to this the reluctance of some administrators to schedule classes that require small sections and one has at least a wide-angle view of the problem.
- [3] From this point forward, the three textbooks will be referred to only by author’s last name and, where warranted, page number. Dates of publication will not be repeated in the interest of efficiency.

- [4] More troubling for rhetoricians is how the complexity of Burke's thought has been reduced to finite taxonomies—such as the pentad and ratios. According to Black (1980, p. 335), Burke's dramatism "begins promisingly with the expectation that a static taxonomy will not suffice to account for phenomena so mutable and unstable as rhetorical transactions," but "ends by sponsoring a taxonomy."
- [5] While graduate courses tend to use critical essays rather than textbooks, some textbooks, such as Bazerman and Prior's book, are clearly intended for advanced students. Moreover, as I have suggested, textbooks may be a viable supplement for graduate students taking their first course in rhetoric (e.g., students enrolled in technical communication programs). In the case of undergraduate courses, the brand of criticism outlined in the textbooks is overwhelmingly personal criticism (i.e., find a curious artifact and analyze it for greater self-understanding). Such criticism is typically bereft of community, including the community of the classroom and the student's local community. What we should be concerned about in the case of undergraduate courses in rhetorical criticism is not how textbooks distinguish between textbook criticism and the scholarly practice of rhetorical criticism (as Benoit does), but how they avoid community altogether. The challenge for the undergraduate instructor is to negotiate the tension between criticism as a pursuit of self-understanding and criticism as the critic's intervention in the public's understanding of texts. Service learning projects may provide one way forward at the undergraduate level.

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